

# The Do-It-Alls

**If you've made the decision, we've done the tests! We present here a comparison of seven monochrome laser multi-functional devices**

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**M**ost offices—big or small—still rely heavily on paper documents rather than soft copies: the “paperless office” is a phrase that is almost out of vogue. And as a result, printers, scanners, copiers and fax machines are still an essential part of offices.

Now, why are MFDs as popular as they are? There are many answers, the main one being their considerably lower prices as compared to the combined prices of standalone components. A second reason is the small desktop footprint. Third, the adoption of MFDs in an office makes for fewer machines, and therefore lower maintenance costs.

MFDs also increase the efficiency of the workforce by reducing the need to go back and forth between machines.

Within the MFD segment, we must ask, why laser MFDs? Well, laser MFDs are considerably more expensive than their inkjet counterparts, but offer much superior print quality. They require lower maintenance, and running costs, too, are much lower. The cost per print is much lower than that of inkjets; this is especially true with small and medium businesses where the workload consists of a moderately large volume of prints each month.

To help you decide on a laser MFD, we present here a mini-shootout of monochrome laser MFDs available in the Indian market. Mono laser MFDs are expensive and are not targeted at home users, but rather at the SoHo and SMB segments.

The mono MFDs we received for this shootout came from Canon, Lexmark, Samsung, Sharp and Xerox. These were the Canon MF3110, Lexmark X215, Samsung SCX-4100, SCX-4521F and SF-565P, Xerox WorkCentre PE220, and the Sharp AM-400. Of these, the Sharp AM-400 belonged in a different class—it is copier-based, whereas the rest are printer-based. We therefore didn't directly compare it with the others.

As always, ours isn't the final word, but this comparison should definitely help you decide on an MFD—assuming, of course, that you've already decided that it's a mono laser MFD you want to go with.

## FEATURES

### Printing

#### DPI

A higher dpi (dots per inch) means better image quality and hence sharper output, which is good for graphics-heavy documents or those with small fonts. The Canon MF3110 supports the highest printer optical resolution of 1200 x 600 dpi, while the others were mostly at 600 x 600 dpi. The Samsung SF-565P had the lowest print resolution of 300 x 300 dpi; Samsung is targeting the Office Automation market, and this MFD is specifically targeted at replacing a fax machine—hence the lower dpi.

#### Paper Capacity

All the MFDs we tested have input paper tray capacities of 250 sheets except for the Samsung SCX-4521F and Xerox WorkCentre PE220, whose input tray capacity is only 150 sheets. The Lexmark and Samsung SF-565P boasted of the highest output tray capacities of 150 sheets each, while the Canon MF3110 had a capacity of 60; the rest had output trays that held only 50 sheets.

#### Duplex Printing

Dual-sided printing wasn't featured in any of the MFDs we tested this time round, which is surprising, since it is important for both the SoHo and SMB segments - it facilitates easy printing of booklets and such. Duplex printing also saves on paper, and is therefore more environment-friendly.

#### Duty Cycles

The Canon MF3110 has the highest printer duty cycle—15,000 prints per month—whereas most of the others have a duty cycle of 10,000. The Samsung SF-565P has the lowest duty cycle—4,200—which is still all right for an MFD that aims at replacing a fax machine.

### Scanning Optical Resolution

A higher scan resolution means you can better extract the finer details from an image or document. The Canon MF3110 supports the highest optical scan resolution—1200 x 600